

What else to watch: *Brothers and Sisters of the Toda Family* (1941) ■ *There Was a Father* (1942) ■ *The Flavor of Green Tea Over Rice* (1952) ■ *Tokyo Twilight* (1957) ■ *Equinox Flower* (1958) ■ *Good Morning* (1959) ■ *The End of Summer* (1961)

The children return home for Tomi's funeral. Over the funeral dinner, the conversation turns into a discussion of the inheritance with almost indecent speed.

children: Kyoko (Kyoko Kagawa), an unmarried daughter who lives with them at home; Keizo (Shiro Osaka), their youngest son, who works in Osaka; Koichi (Sô Yamamura), a doctor living in Tokyo with a wife and two sons of his own; and Shige (Haruko Sugimura), also a Tokyoite, who runs a beauty salon. A fifth child, a son, died in World War II.

A journey

Shukichi and Tomi decide to pay a visit to their children in Tokyo and meet their grandchildren for the first time, and embark on a train trip to the hurly-burly of the city. They are unfailingly positive and polite, but viewers sense the pair's disappointment in the way their offspring have turned out. None of the children make time for their parents in their busy schedules. Indeed, it seems that Noriko (Setsuko Hara), the widow of their dead son, is the only person who cares about them. At one point, the parents are packed off by Koichi to a coastal spa, so that the room in which they are staying can be used for a business meeting.

Static observer

This funny-sad odyssey is observed in Ozu's trademark style: through a static camera positioned low



down, at the eye level of a person seated on a *tatami* mat. Characters come and go, moving in and out of the frame, but Ozu sees everything, as though a silent and invisible observer planted in every scene. The camera's positioning is all about tradition, just as the story it records is about the mutation of family life and an ancient culture in the age of modernity.

"Let's go home," says Shukichi to his wife after a few days. "Yes," replies Tomi. In their words is an

acceptance between them, an acknowledgment that their shared role as parents has become redundant. This sparse exchange is typical of the couple's interaction in that few words are spoken but much is said. It is also Ozu's way of telling stories on film: a small and fleeting moment that contains huge significance.

The couple is sitting on a sea wall in their spa gowns. As Tomi gets up, she has a dizzy spell. "It's because I didn't sleep well," she explains to her concerned husband. Shukichi's face tells us what he is thinking: she is going home to die, which she does a few days later. Now it is the turn of their children to make a journey for the family. ■

“This place is meant for the younger generation.”

Shukichi / Tokyo Story